



Knowledge Navigators

04 / AGENTIC

The Agentic Search Playbook.

How autonomous AI agents shortlist vendors in 2026 — and the engineering that makes your brand the one they choose.

A FIELD GUIDE FOR MARKETING LEADERS & ENGINEERS

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WHY THIS MATTERS

The buyer is no longer human.

For twenty years, discovery ended with a person looking at a list and choosing. That step is being deleted. Buyers now delegate research, comparison and even purchase to autonomous AI agents.

The agent reads the live web, calls tools and APIs, and returns a decision the human merely approves. There is no impression, no click, no landing page to optimize — only the agent's shortlist, and whether you survived it.

The new unit of visibility

Not a ranking. Not a citation. A place on a shortlist an agent assembles in seconds and acts on without ever showing the buyer a results page. If you are filtered out, no analytics event will ever tell you it happened.

DEFINITION

What Agentic Search actually is.

Agentic Search is discovery driven by an autonomous agent instead of a human scanning results. A user asks ChatGPT, Perplexity, Gemini or Claude to research, compare and sometimes buy on their behalf — and it does.

How it differs from GEO & AEO

- GEO optimizes for being cited inside an answer a human reads.
- AEO optimizes for being the passage an engine extracts.
- Agentic Search optimizes for being selected by an agent that acts without a human reading anything at all.

Shared technical foundation. Completely different decision criteria and KPIs.

THE MODEL

How an agent decides.

1 · Retrieve

The agent gathers candidates from search, feeds, APIs and its own knowledge. If you are not retrievable and machine-readable, you never enter the set.

2 · Verify

It checks claims against third-party evidence. Unverifiable assertions are discounted. Reviews, consistent entity data and credible citations carry the weight.

3 · Compare & select

It scores the survivors on fit, price, trust and task-resolution, then commits to a recommendation or an action. One winner; the rest are invisible.

LEVER 1

Make your data machine-consumable.

Agents act on structured facts, not marketing prose. Every fact a buyer's agent needs must be retrievable and parseable without guessing.

- Product, Offer, Service, Review and AggregateRating schema with stable entity IDs.
- Pricing, availability and specifications in structured, current form.
- Product and data feeds an agent can fetch directly.
- Clean, documented, accessible API endpoints where transactions happen.

Rule of thumb: if a fact only exists inside a paragraph, an agent may miss it. If it exists in schema or a feed, the agent can trust and use it.

LEVER 2

Build verifiable trust.

An agent will not stake its recommendation on claims it cannot verify. Trust is the single biggest tiebreaker on an agent shortlist.

- Independent reviews and ratings the agent can cross-check.
- Consistent name, address and entity data across the open web.
- Credible third-party citations and mentions.
- Explicit, honest comparison content that positions you accurately versus named alternatives.

Counter-intuitive but proven: telling an agent exactly when you are the wrong choice increases how often it picks you when you are the right one.

LEVER 3

Resolve the task in one pass.

Agents prefer sources that let them finish the job without bouncing elsewhere. Restructure key pages so a single retrieval answers the whole task.

- What you do, who it is for, and the outcome — stated plainly up top.
- What it costs, or the honest range and what drives it.
- How you compare to the obvious alternatives.
- Exactly how to act next — book, buy, contact, integrate.

Decision-ready content, extractable in one pass, with zero friction that forces the agent to look at a competitor to complete its task.

LEVER 4

Get agent-interface ready.

The frontier of Agentic Search is direct interaction: the buyer's agent talks to your systems and transacts, with no page in between.

- Documented, accessible endpoints for inventory, pricing and booking.
- Model Context Protocol (MCP) style integrations agents can call.
- Real-time answers instead of stale, cached guesses.

Brands that expose clean, queryable interfaces now will be the default the moment agent-to-agent commerce becomes routine.

MEASUREMENT

Track agent-inclusion rate.

There is no click to count, so measure selection directly. Treat it as rank tracking for a surface your competitors are not watching yet.

- Define repeatable agentic task prompts for your category.
- Run them on a schedule across ChatGPT, Perplexity, Gemini and Claude.
- Score: are you shortlisted? recommended? against which named rivals?
- Capture the agent's verbatim reasoning for every include and exclude.

The exclusion reasons are gold — they are a prioritized fix list written by the exact system you are optimizing for.

90 DAYS

A starting sprint.

Weeks 1–2 · Baseline

Run the agent shortlist audit. Capture inclusion rate and exclusion reasons across the major agents.

Weeks 3–6 · Data & trust

Ship structured product/service schema and feeds. Close the highest-weighted trust gaps the agents named.

Weeks 7–10 · Task resolution

Rewrite top-intent pages for single-pass resolution and honest comparison.

Weeks 11–12 · Re-measure

Re-run the audit. Compare inclusion rate. Lock the wins; queue the next exclusions.

Win the shortlist first.

Agent shortlists are won by structured, verifiable, machine-readable signals that take months to compound. Build agent-readiness now and you own the default position before your category is contested.

By the time agentic traffic is obvious in your analytics, the shortlist has already hardened around whoever prepared first.

Work with us

We run agent-readiness audits and full Agentic Search engagements for European brands. We will show you where agents pick a competitor over you — and the exact reason.

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